



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times
BRETT FELDMAN, director of USC Street Medicine, gives a shot to treat addiction to Ariana Montero, 46.

Medic helps fill a void on the streets

Brett Feldman and his USC team dole out medication and hugs to homeless people.

By JAMES RAINEY

Starting out as a young medical practitioner, Brett Feldman sometimes walked for miles to treat homeless people living in the wooded outskirts of Allentown, Pa. Feldman was determined to treat those in need, wherever the path led.

Nineteen years later and 2,700 miles to the west, Feldman now helps lead the USC Street Medicine program he helped create. In Los Angeles, the epicenter of homelessness in America, the physician's assistant never needs to look far to find someone in need.

"I never had to walk by somebody before that I couldn't help. And that took a lot to get used to," said Feldman, a short man with the muscles of a bodybuilder and the dreamy affect of a poet. "That's why we focus on the one-on-one, instead of trying to count big, big numbers. Eventually, we hope the ones add up to something bigger."

On a recent morning, Feldman and his colleagues made their rounds, visiting people living in ragamuffin tents on sidewalks and cranies just west of downtown. Feldman, medical resident Israel Garcia and community health worker Raymond Luna patched up wounds, tested blood pressure, administered shots and handed out medications.

And they listened. They listened to beating hearts. They listened to lungs rattling with chronic disease. They listened to the stories of people accustomed to being ignored.

"A lot of people drive by like you're an eyesore or something," said Zarak Walden, 58, sitting inside his stand-up tent, one of more than a dozen lining Beacon Avenue, within view of downtown's luxury high-rises. "These guys don't drive by. They stop. They talk. They communicate. Someone is showing love for you."

A true healer walks among them

Feldman and his crew came to check back on Walden's girlfriend, a 24-year-old struggling to recover from having her leg and pelvis shattered in a fall from a fire escape. Feldman found her lying on just a couple of blankets on top of the concrete, moaning in pain. [See **Medic**, A8]

How L.A. Unified's AI gamble led to FBI raids

By Richard Winton, Howard Blume and Brittney Mejia

Los Angeles Unified schools Supt. Alberto Carvalho introduced "Ed" the AI chatbot amid fanfare in March 2024, touting a revolutionary tool that would put the district at the leading edge of school technology.

But the multimillion-dollar project failed within months and never fully launched.

Now, the deal to bring Ed to the nation's second-largest school district — and Carvalho's longtime association with Debra Kerr, the Florida consultant who helped sell the technology to the district — is under scrutiny as part of a sweeping FBI investigation that included early morning raids Wednesday at Carvalho's San Pedro home and district office and a home owned by Kerr.

The LAUSD contract was inked with a Boston-based startup called AllHere. But behind the scenes, the company was

collapsing and ultimately declared bankruptcy. Its founder, Joanna Smith-Griffin, was indicted on allegations that she defrauded investors. The charges were filed eight months after she and Carvalho stood side by side during the chatbot unveiling.

The raids mark a dramatic expansion into the activities and records of Carvalho and Kerr, who has filed a claim saying that the now-defunct AllHere owes her \$630,000.

Neither Carvalho nor Kerr have been charged with a crime. The FBI has not released information about the nature or scope of the investigation; search warrant affidavits are sealed.

Sources with knowledge of the probe told The Times that Carvalho, not LAUSD, is a focus of the investigation. The raids are connected to the failed chatbot contract [See **Carvalho**, A7]

Virtual tie emerges in governor's race

Three Democrats, two Republicans top crowded field ahead of the June primary.

By SEEMA MEHTA

With just over three months to go before California's primary election, the race to replace Gov. Gavin Newsom remains as murky as L.A.'s foggy June gloom.

A newly released poll by the Public Policy Institute of California found that the five candidates topping the crowded field hover within 4 percentage points of one another. Among the five, for-

mer Rep. Katie Porter, Rep. Eric Swalwell and hedge fund founder Tom Steyer lead the way among the Democrats, and conservative commentator Steve Hilton and Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco are the top Republicans.

"The race is unsettled," said Mark Baldassare, PPIC's survey director, adding the voters' deep concerns about affordability will be a driving factor in the race. Nearly two-thirds of likely voters, and 78% of young voters, said affordability would be critical in determining which candidate they support. "That issue is one that we can't say enough about this year."

In a crowded field of a dozen prominent candidates, Hilton had the support of 14% of likely voters, Porter 13%, Bianco 12%, Swalwell 11% and Steyer 10%, according to the poll. No other candidate received the support of more than 5% of respondents. One in 10 likely voters was undecided.

The two candidates who receive the most votes in the June primary will move on to the general election regardless of party identification. With nine prominent Democrats in the field, this has led to concerns among party leaders that the Democratic candidates may splinter the vote and the two Republicans could advance to the

November ballot. No Republican has been elected to statewide office in California since 2006.

California's top-two primary system went into effect in 2011. Since then, Republicans have rarely registered among the top two candidates in polling in gubernatorial and U.S. Senate races. Businessman John Cox led Newsom in one poll in the 2018 primary; former Los Angeles Dodger Steve Garvey led then-Rep. Adam Schiff in three primary polls in 2024.

But, reflecting how large the Democratic field is and how fractured the party's voters are in the 2026 governor's race, Republicans have [See **Governor**, A6]

U.S. cowboy's diverse roots

Rubio credited Spain. Historians find origins that include Mexican, Indigenous and African heritage.

By Patrick J. McDonnell



CARLIN STEIHL Los Angeles Times
EMILIO CARRANZA SR. calls for a backup saddle when a stirrup breaks in Dairyland, Calif., in July.

MEXICO CITY — Few figures occupy as prominent a niche in U.S. lore as the American cowboy, that embodiment of rugged individualism celebrated in dime novels, vintage radio, TV and Hollywood blockbusters.

But recent musings from Secretary of State Marco Rubio have fueled a sometimes-acrimonious debate — mostly on social media — about the origins of the tall-hatted buckaroo who, with the help of a trusty steed and a six-gun, helped tame the West.

At the Munich Security Conference in Germany this month, Rubio stated that the "entire romance of the cowboy archetype that became synonymous with the American West" was "born in Spain."

Hurling an indignant riposte was one of the Florida Republican's ideological antagonists, New York Democratic Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, who declared: "I believe that Mexicans and [See **Cowboys**, A4]

Netflix bows out of the auction for Warner Bros.

The streaming company declines to raise its bid after being topped by Paramount.

By MEG JAMES AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — Netflix bowed out of the Warner Bros. Discovery sweepstakes Thursday, conceding the prize to Paramount Skydance, a dramatic capstone to one of Hollywood's biggest auctions in years.

The reversal came after Warner Bros. Discovery switched gears, announcing that Paramount's revised bid had topped the one on the table from Netflix.

Netflix had been given four business days to regroup and potentially submit a higher offer; but late Thursday, Netflix announced that it had no intention to raise its bid.

"We've always been disciplined, and at the price required to match Paramount Skydance's latest offer, the deal is no longer financially attractive, so we are declining to match the Paramount Skydance bid," Netflix Co-

Chief Executives Ted Sarandos and Greg Peters said in a statement.

Netflix also felt pressure from its investors. The streaming giant's stock, which edged up 2.3% Thursday to close at \$84.59, has been pounded since it initially emerged as the top bidder in December with a deal valued at \$82.7 billion.

The streaming giant's flagging stock and mounting resistance to its deal in Washington appears to have contributed to the decision to pull the plug on its effort to bulk up with HBO, HBO Max, the storied Burbank studios and its spacious film campus.

In addition, Paramount Chairman David Ellison and his billionaire father Larry Ellison, who is backing the deal, demonstrated they had mettle and determination to out-spend and out-last their competitors in their quest to build a new entertainment juggernaut.

The elder Ellison, who is close to Trump, also leveraged his close ties with the administration to support Paramount's bid and cast doubt on Netflix's chances.

The Warner Bros. deal [See **Netflix**, A12]



ANDREW LEYDEN Getty Images
NETFLIX CEO Ted Sarandos arrives at the White House to discuss a bid for Warner Bros. Discovery.

L.A. risks loss of transit funding

Short-staffed agency will seek two-year extension from state for three city projects.

By MELISSA GOMEZ

Four years ago, Boyle Heights and Skid Row had something to celebrate: state grants to build new sidewalks and protected bike lanes.

But now, more than \$100 million from the state for the transportation projects in some of the neediest parts of Los Angeles is in jeopardy because city officials say they don't have enough staff to complete the projects.

The issue is part of the continuing fallout from a \$1-billion budget shortfall the city faced last year. Officials avoided mass layoffs but closed the gap with budget cuts to city departments, including the Bureau of Engineering, Department of Transportation, Bureau of Street Lighting and Bureau of Street Services. Those cuts included eliminating open positions, resulting in smaller staffs.

"To know that the funding is there and that we have to give it back because the city says it can't find the bodies to do the work is a scandal," said Estela Lopez, executive director for the L.A. Downtown Industrial District Business Improvement District. She has long advocated for more resources on Skid Row, including improved accessibility for pedestrians. [See **Funding**, A7]

Cuba alleges 'infiltration'
Government identifies two passengers in fatal speedboat shooting who were wanted by authorities. **WORLD, A2**

D4vd is 'target' of murder probe
Disembodied body of 14-year-old Celeste Rivas Hernandez was found in the singer's Tesla. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Suicide searches to prompt alerts
Instagram says it will warn parents if their teens repeatedly inquire about self-harm terms. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather
Very warm.
L.A. Basin: 90/58. **B6**

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